

River

When freshwater on Earth's surface flows from mountains and hills down to the sea, it is called a river. Small rivers are called streams. As rivers flow, they wear away, or erode, the surrounding rocks and leave deposits of soil and grit, creating shapes and patterns in the landscape.

Young rivers flow rapidly down steep slopes, creating waterfalls and rapids (fast-flowing parts of a river).

Birth of a river

Rivers usually begin their lives on mountains where rainwater or snow gathers and forms small channels. As water collects in larger and larger channels, rivers are born. The start of a river is called its source.

Waterfalls often form in the early stages of a river. They play an important role in erosion—the water wears away rocks as it cascades downward.

As rivers run through steep slopes, they gradually wear away the rocks. Over thousands of years, they carve out V-shaped valleys.

Tributaries are freshwater streams that join up with rivers.

Rivers are found on every continent.

As the water swings from side to side, it wears away (erodes) S-shaped channels in the landscape. These bends in the river are called meanders.

Old river

Mature, or old, rivers flow down gentler slopes. Here, most of the steep ground has been eroded away. These rivers split into many streams along the way. They do not flow as fast as young rivers.

